

Incident Alert 0016. TLP CLEAR.			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU – Russian Sanctioned Media Accessible to EU Audiences on Google Play and Search		30/06/2024	2

Summary

- As of June 28 2024, at least 5 apps banned by the EU, posing as such, or consistently amplifying their content are accessible to EU audiences.
- 21 sanctioned Russian media websites are also accessible on Google Search.
- [Council Regulation No 269/2014](#) prohibits hosting content from these channels or making them available to EU audiences on video-sharing platforms, as clarified in [Commission guidance](#) updated mid-May 2024.

Incident – When, Who did what, to say what, to whom, why?

Despite these legal provisions, as of late June 2024, a number of Google services still make content produced by Russian state-controlled media and media personalities on the [EU sanctions list](#) accessible to European audiences.

On Google Play, applications giving access to sanctioned media entities' content are freely available to EU-based users. These applications, which exclusively or frequently share content by sanctioned media organizations, are discoverable through a simple search (e.g. "RT, "RT documentary") on the Play Store.

On Google Search, links to sanctioned entities' websites or mirror sites are shown in search results of EU-based users, including links to 18 sanctioned media mirror or official websites. Note that this list is not exhaustive, as new mirror websites of sanctioned Russian media often emerge.

The queries used to surface these websites were basic and susceptible to be typed by typical users of the search engine (e.g. "Sputnik", "RT en español", "RT en français").

In addition, the suggestions that appear in the search bar when typing a basic query are very effective in connecting users to mirror websites. For instance, when typing "RT France" (a query which yielded no mirror sites on the first results page), our researcher received a Google-generated suggestion to type "RT France direct", a query which yielded mirror site <https://fra.mobileapiru.com/en-direct> as the first result.

Two e-commerce websites linked to sanctioned media, along with a page on an e-commerce platform offering products from these sanctioned sources, also appear in Google Search results for EU-based users.

Narrative

N/A

Impact

Reach: Google does not giving exact statistics. The apps have achieved at least 35k downloads.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Facilitate State Propaganda](#) – Spread Russian operational content.

[Bypass Content Blocking](#) – using alternative URLs and apps to get past sanctions.

Recommendations

- Action taken: Case reported to Google (28/06/2024), European Institutions, and EU member states affected.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Sanctions, Russia	Se report	Charles Terroille , Science Feedback Saman Nazari , A4E	App, website	YouTube